

SEATED TWIST

Ardha Matsyendrasana

This seated twist will wake up small muscles along your spine and stimulate digestion. Practicing twists mindfully in yoga can help prevent injury from twists you do in everyday life. Take care not to twist too far if you have spinal disk issues or osteoporosis.

THE BIG PICTURE

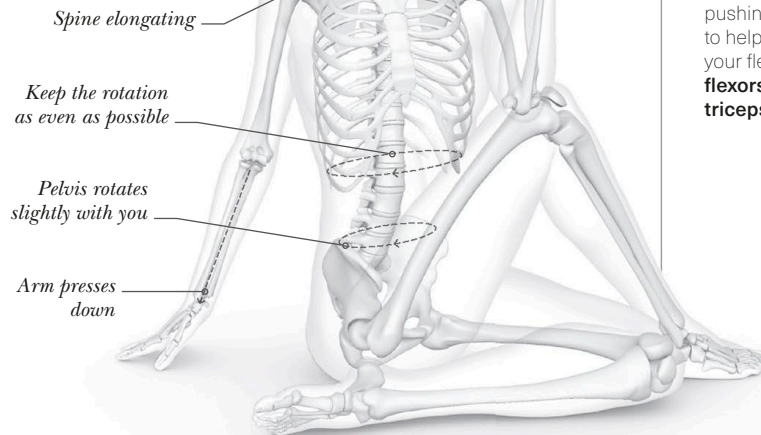
Your back muscles and abdominals dynamically engage and stretch as you rotate your spine. Your thighs and hips—particularly around your buttocks—are stretching as they rotate outward. Your lowered arm presses down to help you find more length along your spine.

KEY

- Joints
- Muscles
- Engaging
- Engaging while stretching
- Stretching

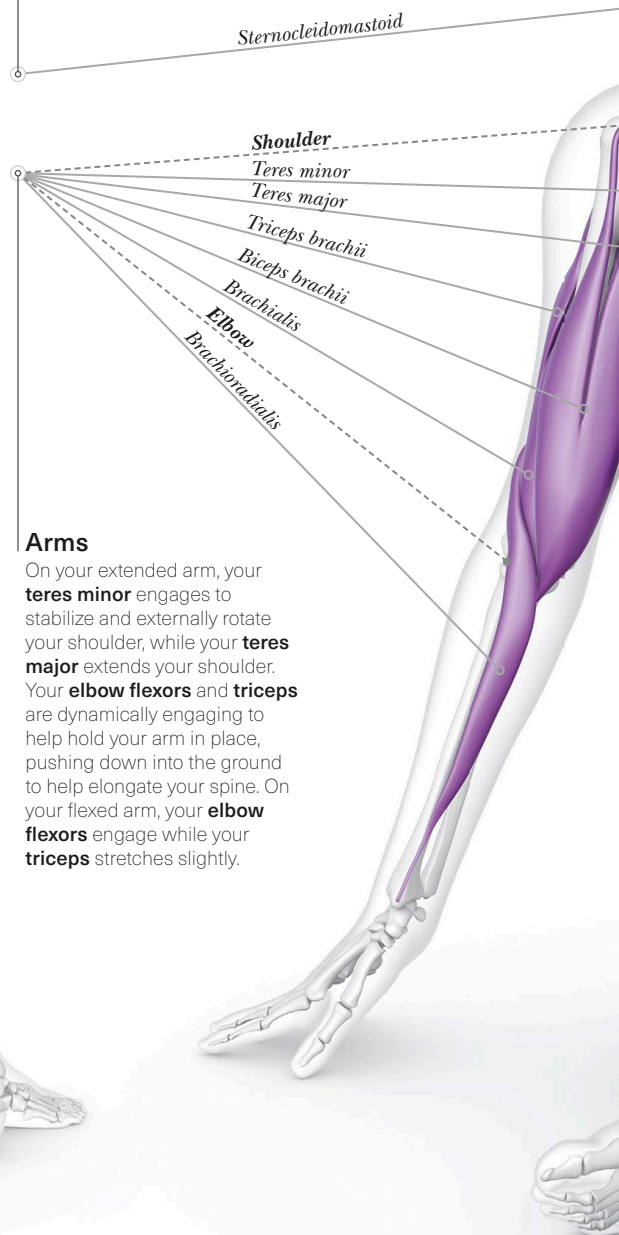
ALIGNMENT

Prioritize elongating your spine over rotating more or leaning. If you do decide to rotate more deeply, try to use your core muscles instead of pulling with the external force of your arms.



Neck

To rotate your neck, on the contralateral side of axial rotation (side you are rotating away from, model's left side on this image), your **rotatores**, **multifidus**, **sternocleidomastoid**, and **semispinalis cervicis** engage while stretching on the ipsilateral side (the side you are rotating toward). Your **splenius capitis** and **splenius cervicis** engage on the ipsilateral side, and stretch on the contralateral.



Arms

On your extended arm, your **teres minor** engages to stabilize and externally rotate your shoulder, while your **teres major** extends your shoulder. Your **elbow flexors** and **triceps** are dynamically engaging to help hold your arm in place, pushing down into the ground to help elongate your spine. On your flexed arm, your **elbow flexors** engage while your **triceps** stretches slightly.